

The Fall of the House of Usher

Edgar Allan Poe · 1839

First published: Burton's Gentleman's Magazine, Sep 1839

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Fall_of_the_House_of_Usher (revision 14833569), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about decay of family and mind?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about fear and the imagination?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about the double?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Fall of the House of Usher	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*decay of family and mind* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Fall of the House of Usher

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Edgar Allan Poe's life or times connects to decay of family and mind in “The Fall of the House of Usher”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (decay of family and mind, fear and the imagination, the double).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

Poe wrote within the Gothic tradition (crumbling mansions, ancient families, premature burial) popularized by English and German writers, but he turned its horrors inward: the decay of a house mirrors the decay of a mind. The 1830s were also a time of fascination with nervous illness and "hypochondriasis."

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine (Philadelphia) in September 1839, where Poe was an editor; collected in Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque (1840).

Then: Contemporary reviewers praised its atmosphere; it was among the tales that built Poe's reputation abroad, especially in France through Charles Baudelaire's translations in the 1850s.

Now: It is considered a masterpiece of Gothic fiction and the clearest example of Poe's "unity of effect," often read psychologically (the house as the mind; Madeline as Roderick's double).

Overview (spoiler-free)

A narrator answers a desperate letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and arrives at a gloomy mansion beside a dark lake. Roderick is ill with nervous terror, and his twin sister Madeline is wasting away.

Main themes

- decay of family and mind: house, family and mind fall together.
- fear and the imagination: Roderick fears fear itself.

- the double: twins, reflections, a house and its image in the lake.

Why it matters

The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.

Spoilers · teacher only

Madeline apparently dies and is entombed in a vault; days later, during a storm, she breaks out, falls on Roderick, and both die. The narrator flees as the house splits along its fissure and sinks into the tarn.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Fall of the House of Usher: Describe a place that made you feel uneasy. Which details created the feeling?
Prompt: Before we open The Fall of the House of Usher: Describe a place that made you feel uneasy. Which details created the feeling?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
Gothic fiction; atmosphere; pathetic fallacy; doppelgänger (double); premature burial; tarn (a small mountain lake).

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. Poe wrote within the Gothic tradition (crumbling mansions, ancient families, premature burial) popularized by English and German writers, but he turned its horrors inward: the decay of a house mirrors the decay of a mind. The 1830s were also a time of fascination with nervous illness and "hypochondriasis." Publication and reception. First published in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine (Philadelphia) in September 1839, where Poe was an editor; collected in Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque (1840). Then: Contemporary reviewers praised its atmosphere; it was among the tales that built Poe's reputation abroad, especially in France through Charles Baudelaire's translations in the 1850s. Now: It is considered a masterpiece of Gothic fiction and the clearest example of Poe's "unity of effect," often read psychologically (the house as the mind; Madeline as Roderick's double).

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator rides alone through a whole dull, dark, soundless autumn day. Next, craft. I notice three heavy adjectives in a row, all with low, flat sounds. The strongest word is "soundless": it removes even noise, so the world feels dead before he reaches the house. Then, effect. How does the opening phrase create the story's mood? My answer: Poe builds gloom before anything happens, which is his "single effect": the reader is already uneasy at the first sentence.

> *During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 4)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator rides alone through a whole dull, dark, soundless autumn day. Next, craft. I notice three heavy adjectives in a row, all with low, flat sounds. The strongest word is "soundless": it removes even noise, so the world feels dead before he reaches the house. Then, effect. How does the opening phrase create the story's mood? My answer: Poe builds gloom before anything happens, which is his "single effect": the reader is already uneasy at the first sentence.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): A narrator answers a desperate letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and arrives at a gloomy mansion beside a dark lake. Roderick is ill with nervous terror, and his twin sister Madeline is wasting away. Themes to track: decay of family and mind: house, family and mind fall together. fear and the imagination: Roderick fears fear itself. the double: twins, reflections, a house and its image in the lake.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: decay of family and mind. Prediction: the cracked, gloomy house will mirror the health of the Usher family. Question: is the narrator's fear caused by the house, by Roderick, or by his own imagination?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Fall of the House of Usher: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: decay of family and mind. Prediction: the cracked, gloomy house will mirror the health of the Usher family. Question: is the narrator's fear caused by the house, by Roderick, or by his own imagination?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Fall of the House of Usher still matter? The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.
Anchor question: Why might The Fall of the House of Usher still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).

Poe's mother, the actress Eliza Poe, died of tuberculosis in Richmond in 1811, when he was two, and he published "Usher" in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine in 1839. Name one way this background could shape a story about a decaying family. Answer: Accept answers such as: fear of losing loved ones, as Poe lost his mother; obsession with illness and death; the image of the Usher family and its house slowly dying together.

Exit ticket: Poe's mother, the actress Eliza Poe, died of tuberculosis in Richmond in 1811, when he was two, and he published "Usher" in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine in 1839. Name one way this background could shape a story about a decaying family.

Answer: Accept answers such as: fear of losing loved ones, as Poe lost his mother; obsession with illness and death; the image of the Usher family and its house slowly dying together.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Preview the first reading.

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Fall of the House of Usher.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Fall of the House of Usher" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/usherb.htm)

Lesson 2: The Fall of the House of Usher

Focus: a family and a house collapsing together

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in “The Fall of the House of Usher” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (premature burial, gothic dread, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Premature burial; gothic dread. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…erly than to the after-dream of the reveller upon opium—the bitter lapse into every-day life—th…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees as the house splits along the crack and sinks into the tarn.

Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line.

Significance: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to fear and the imagination because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.
Prompt: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to fear and the imagination because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: unmingled — pure; not mixed with anything else; equivocal — open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead; despaired — abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart; trepidation — a feeling of alarm or dread; profuse — produced or growing in extreme abundance. "unmingled": Origin: an English formation from un- + mingled. "trepidation": Origin: Latin trepidātiō.
Words: unmingled: pure; not mixed with anything else · equivocal: open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead · despaired: abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart · trepidation: a feeling of alarm or dread · profuse: produced or growing in extreme abundance

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme. Setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Imagery: Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images. Symbolism: The House of Usher means both the building and the family line; when one falls, so does the other. Watch for the fissure: the hairline crack that splits the house at the end: a hidden flaw in the family and in Roderick's mind.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim..." slowly and put it in my own words: Roderick tells the narrator he expects to give up his life and his sanity in a struggle with Fear itself. Next, craft. I notice "Fear" is capitalized and called a "phantasm," a ghostly figure he expects to fight. The strongest word is "phantasm": it means an illusion or ghost, so his enemy is in his own mind. Then, effect. Why does Roderick fear he will lose life and reason together? My answer: He knows his terror is consuming him; the line predicts that the collapse of his mind and the collapse of the house will happen together.

> *I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear* *(The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim…" slowly and put it in my own words: Roderick tells the narrator he expects to give up his life and his sanity in a struggle with Fear itself. Next, craft. I notice "Fear" is capitalized and called a "phantasm," a ghostly figure he expects to fight. The strongest word is "phantasm": it means an illusion or ghost, so his enemy is in his own mind. Then, effect. Why does Roderick fear he will lose life and reason together? My answer: He knows his terror is consuming him; the line predicts that the collapse of his mind and the collapse of the house will happen together.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The fissure is small at first, as Roderick's illness is hidden; it foreshadows the ending. Expected link: decay of family and mind. Ask: How does this line connect to fear and the imagination? Expected: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. (Foreshadowing the collapse.)

> *a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The fissure is small at first, as Roderick's illness is hidden; it foreshadows the ending. Expected link: decay of family and mind.
Ask: How does this line connect to fear and the imagination?
Expected answer: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. (Foreshadowing the collapse.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for setting, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. When the text says “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8), it shows this directly. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.
Task: Annotate the story for setting, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. When the text says “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8), it shows this directly. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling? Ask: is Madeline really alive, or is the ending the narrator's (or Roderick's) hallucination? Use the storm passage.
Anchor question: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
Facilitation: Ask: is Madeline really alive, or is the ending the narrator's (or Roderick's) hallucination? Use the storm passage.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. (“a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”, The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. (“a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”, The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes a family and a house collapsing together. Key takeaway: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character.
- **Imagery:** Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images.
- **Symbolism:** The House of Usher means both the building and the family line; when one falls, so does the other.

Themes and how they develop

- **fear and the imagination:** Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

Symbols and motifs

- **the fissure:** the hairline crack that splits the house at the end: a hidden flaw in the family and in Roderick's mind.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) Foreshadowing the collapse.
- "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) Roderick's prophecy.
- "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92) Roderick's confession during the storm.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his.
Evidence: "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8)
Reasoning: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
unmingled (adjective)	pure; not mixed with anything else	*I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.*	"unmingled": Origin: an English formation from un- + mingled. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/unmingled#Etymology)
equivocal (adjective)	open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead	*I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition.*	
despaired (verb)	abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart	*It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.*	
trepidation (noun)	a feeling of alarm or dread	*He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.*	"trepidation": Origin: Latin trepidātiō. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://

			en.wiktionary.org/wiki/trepidation#Etymology)
profuse (adjective)	produced or growing in extreme abundance	*The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered.*	
perusal (noun)	a careful reading	*His chief delight, however, was found in the perusal of an exceedingly rare and curious book in quarto Gothic—the manual of a forgotten church—the Vigiliae Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiae Maguntinae.*	
overspread (verb)	spread across or over	*Minute fungi overspread the whole exterior, hanging in a fine tangled web-work from the eaves.*	"overspread": Origin: an English formation from over- + spread. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/overspread#Etymology)
accosted (verb)	approached and spoken to	*He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.*	"accosted": Origin of "accost": Middle French accoster; earlier Old French acoster ("to stand beside"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/accost#Etymology)
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*Shaking off from my spirit what must have been a dream, I scanned more narrowly the real aspect of the building.*	"narrowly": Origin: an English formation from narrow + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)
abhorrence (noun)	hate coupled with disgust	*I have, indeed, no abhorrence of danger, except in its absolute effect—in terror.*	

Discussion questions

1. Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with decay of family and mind?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Roderick wrote asking for his company
2. What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A barely visible crack running down the wall
3. Who is Madeline? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Roderick's twin sister
4. What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: She is entombed while still alive
5. What happens to the house at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: It splits apart and sinks into the tarn
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Fall of the House of Usher" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Fall of the House of Usher"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Fall of the House of Usher" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings." What does "unmingled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: unmingled: pure; not mixed with anything else.
10. Reread: "I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition." What does "equivocal" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: equivocal: open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Fall of the House of Usher" suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the

building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. On imagery: Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins "The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty.", why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Fall of the House of Usher", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a…
6. As the opening story, what does "The Fall of the House of Usher" set up that the rest of The Fall of the House of Usher will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with decay of family and mind? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. On symbolism: The House of Usher means both the building

and the family line; when one falls, so does the other. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. On setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Fall of the House of Usher” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any

position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Fall of the House of Usher”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to fear and the imagination: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. On setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Fall of the House of Usher” treats a family and a house collapsing together with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Fall of the House of Usher see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve decay of family and mind? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with

textual clues.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “His chief delight, however, was found in the _____ of an exceedingly rare and curious book in quarto Gothic—the manual of a forgotten church—the Vigiliae Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiae Maguntinae.” Word bank: despaired, perusal, unmingled, equivocal

   Key: perusal

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The general furniture was _____, comfortless, antique, and tattered.” Word bank: unmingled, equivocal, despaired, profuse

   Key: profuse

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] What happens to the house at the end?

   A. It burns down

   B. The narrator inherits it

   C. It splits apart and sinks into the tarn

   D. It is sold

   Key: C (It splits apart and sinks into the tarn)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8: "a barely _____ fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction"

   Key: perceptible

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.3] Who is Madeline?

   A. The housekeeper

   B. Roderick's twin sister

   C. Roderick's wife

   D. The narrator's cousin

   Key: B (Roderick's twin sister)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He _____ me with trepidation and passed on." Word bank: unmingled, accosted, despaired, equivocal

   Key: accosted

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.3] Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher?

   A. He is lost in a storm

   B. Roderick wrote asking for his company

   C. He wants to buy it

   D. He is a doctor called to Madeline

   Key: B (Roderick wrote asking for his company)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.3] What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible?

   A. She is entombed while still alive

   B. She runs away

   C. She burns the house

   D. She marries the narrator

   Key: A (She is entombed while still alive)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.3] What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front?

   A. A barely visible crack running down the wall

   B. A missing door

   C. A broken window

   D. A fallen tower

   Key: A (A barely visible crack running down the wall)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92: "We have put her _____ in the tomb"

    Key: living

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Minute fungi _____ the whole exterior, hanging in a fine tangled web-work from the eaves.” Word bank: overspread, unmingled, despaired, equivocal

    Key: overspread

12. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.3] Claim: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8).

    Sample answer: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once. The words “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself. This develops fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

13. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · L.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Roderick's confession during the storm. The words “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself. This develops fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

14. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive only in part. In support, “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) bears it out: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once. But “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) complicates it, because this detail (roderick's prophecy) gives the reader a second explanation to weigh against the claim's reading. So the claim holds only once it is qualified: it explains much of the story, but it has to account for that passage too, which it does not do on its own.

15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Synthesis: trace how fear and the imagination develops from the opening of “The Fall of the House of Usher” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

    Sample answer: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. The words “The Fall of the House of Usher” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself. This develops fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · L.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Roderick's prophecy. The words “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm,…” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself. This develops fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 11? “It was with _____ that I could bring myself to admit the identity of the wan being before me with the companion of my early boyhood.”

    A. exaggeration

    B. insoluble

    C. expression

    D. difficulty

    Key: D (difficulty)

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 5? “_____, in this mansion of gloom I now proposed to myself a sojourn of some weeks.”

    A. Nevertheless

    B. occupations

    C. improvisations

    D. exaggeration

    Key: A (Nevertheless)

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 7: “Ihave said that the sole effect of my somewhat childish _____—that of looking down within the tarn—had been to deepen the first singular impression.” Word bank: experiment, exaggeration, moments, Nevertheless

    Key: experiment

20. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 4 reveal about the character or situation? “I say insufferable; for the feeling was unrelieved by any of that half-pleasurable, because poetic, sentiment, with which the mind usually receives even the sternest natural images of the desolate or terrible.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 4) accurately and quotes “insufferable” and “pleasurable”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 19 reveal about the character or situation? “An excited and highly distempered ideality threw a sulphureous lustre over all.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 19) accurately and quotes “sulphureous” and “distempered”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

22. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing the collapse. The words “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the

building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself.

23. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage most clearly show? "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92) Answer in two or three sentences, quoting one word or phrase.
    Sample answer: Roderick's confession during the storm. The words "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself.

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · L.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 7 shapes its tone: "There can be no doubt that the consciousness of the rapid increase of my superstition—for why should I not so term it?—served mainly to accelerate the increase itself." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 7) accurately and quotes "consciousness" and "superstition", saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · L.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 20 shapes its tone: "No outlet was observed in any portion of its vast extent, and no torch, or other artificial source of light was discernible; yet a flood of intense rays rolled throughout, and bathed the whole in a ghastly and inappropriate splendor." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 20) accurately and quotes "inappropriate" and "discernible", saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · L.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 69 shapes its tone: "But, in his disordered fancy, the idea had assumed a more daring character, and trespassed, under certain conditions, upon the kingdom of inorganization." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 69) accurately and quotes "inorganization" and "conditions", saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Connect this passage from paragraph 72 to the story's treatment of decay of family and mind: "At the request of Usher, I personally aided him in the arrangements for the temporary entombment." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 72) accurately and quotes "arrangements" and "entombment", saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to decay of family and mind and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

28. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14: "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason _____, in some struggle

with the grim phantasm, Fear”

Key: together

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · L.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 5 shapes its tone: “Its proprietor, Roderick Usher, had been one of my boon companions in boyhood; but many years had elapsed since our last meeting.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 5) accurately and quotes “companions” and “proprietor”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Connect this passage from paragraph 11 to the story's treatment of decay of family and mind: “Yet the character of his face had been at all times remarkable.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11) accurately and quotes “remarkable” and “character”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to decay of family and mind and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 12: “For something of this nature I had indeed been prepared, no less by his letter, than by _____ of certain boyish traits, and by conclusions deduced from his peculiar physical conformation and temperament.” Word bank: cataleptical, insoluble, occupations, reminiscences

    Key: reminiscences

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Connect this passage from paragraph 17 to the story's treatment of decay of family and mind: “The disease of the lady Madeline had long baffled the skill of her physicians.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 17) accurately and quotes “physicians” and “Madeline”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to decay of family and mind and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.3] Connect this passage from paragraph 74 to the story's treatment of decay of family and mind: “And now, some days of bitter grief having elapsed, an observable change came over the features of the mental disorder of my friend.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 74) accurately and quotes “observable” and “features”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to decay of family and mind and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of decay of family and mind: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

34. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 4: “I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of _____ gloom pervaded my spirit.” Word bank: insufferable, experiment, expression, accordingly

    Key: insufferable

35. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The this device is the story's main character.

    A. Setting

    B. Point of view

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: A (Setting)

36. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · L.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing the collapse. The words “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself. This develops fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

37. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] In the line “I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition.”, what does “equivocal” most nearly mean?

    A. a feeling of alarm or dread

    B. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

    C. pure; not mixed with anything else

    D. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    Key: B (open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead)

38. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Fall of the House of Usher”?

    A. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

    B. The closing of the frontier

    C. A family and a house collapsing together

    D. Wishes that defy fate

    Key: C (A family and a house collapsing together)

39. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] In the line “I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread —and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.”, what does “unmingled” most nearly mean?

    A. a feeling of alarm or dread

    B. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

    C. pure; not mixed with anything else

    D. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    Key: C (pure; not mixed with anything else)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 0, analysis 2, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	9, 1, 17, 18, 11, 2, 19, 7, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	18, 7, 10, 19, 28, 3, 8, 4, 20, 22, 21, 24, 29, 26, 15, 30	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 11, 6, 3, 7, 17, 22, 20, 21, 23, 29, 24, 25, 26, 27, 15	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 9, 5, 31, 7, 18, 23, 20, 21, 25, 29, 12, 26, 32, 30, 33	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 8, 1, 7, 9, 5, 24, 13, 26, 29, 33, 30, 14, 27, 32, 15	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 4, synthesis 6
College Freshman	34, 5, 17, 2, 7, 23, 35, 24, 26, 29, 25, 36, 27, 32, 33, 30	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	1, 37, 2, 7, 9, 38, 25, 26, 29, 24, 14, 30, 32, 36, 33, 16	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 4, synthesis 6
College Junior	4, 34, 7, 9, 5, 38, 22, 25, 24, 26, 29, 27, 33, 30, 32, 14	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 5
College Senior	11, 2, 7, 9, 5, 8, 26, 24, 16, 14, 32, 36, 30, 33, 15, 27	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 2, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	39, 2, 1, 9, 5, 7, 25, 13, 29, 15, 30, 14, 33, 36, 32, 27	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 3, synthesis 7

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Fall of the House of Usher,” how does Poe show a family and a house collapsing together? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In The Fall of the House of Usher, how does Poe develop the idea of a family and a house collapsing together? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of a family and a house collapsing together. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Fall of the House of Usher suggests about a family and a house collapsing together. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses setting in The Fall of the House of Usher to complicate the reader's understanding of a

family and a house collapsing together. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Fall of the House of Usher within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a family and a house collapsing together responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Fall of the House of Usher alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a family and a house collapsing together follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Fall of the House of Usher and its treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as evidence for a larger claim about a family and a house collapsing together in The Fall of the House of Usher. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Fall of the House of Usher.

SAT-style questions

1. *It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “despaired” most nearly mean?

   A. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

   B. approached and spoken to

   C. closely; carefully

   D. hate coupled with disgust

2. *The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty. The windows were long, narrow, and pointed, and at so vast a distance from the black oaken floor as to be altogether inaccessible from within. Feeble gleams of encrimsoned light made their way through the trellissed panes, and served to render sufficiently distinct the more prominent objects around; the eye, however, struggled in vain to reach the remoter angles of the chamber, or the recesses of the vaulted and fretted ceiling. Dark draperies hung upon the walls. The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered. Many books and musical instruments lay scattered*

about, but failed to give any vitality to the scene. I felt that I breathed an atmosphere of sorrow. An air of stern, deep, and irredeemable gloom hung over and pervaded all.

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Fall of the House of Usher"?

A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

B. A family and a house collapsing together

C. Superstition used against a credulous man

D. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

SAT key: 1. A (abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart); 2. B (A family and a house collapsing together)

Unit test

The Fall of the House of Usher: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 7? “Such, I have long known, is the _____ law of all sentiments having terror as a basis.”
   A. paradoxical
   B. experiment
   C. importunate
   D. expression

   Key: A (paradoxical)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 18: “We painted and read together; or I listened, as if in a dream, to the wild _____ of his speaking guitar.” Word bank: imagination, improvisations, insoluble, occupations

   Key: improvisations
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 5: “A letter, however, had lately reached me in a distant part of the country—a letter from him—which, in its wildly _____ nature, had admitted of no other than a personal reply.” Word bank: importunate, moments, cataleptical, insufferable

   Key: importunate
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 4? “There was an iciness, a sinking, a sickening of the heart—an unredeemed dreariness of thought which no goading of the _____ could torture into aught of the sublime.”
   A. insoluble
   B. imagination
   C. difficulty
   D. experiment

   Key: B (imagination)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 11: “We sat down; and for some _____, while he spoke not, I gazed upon him with a feeling half of pity, half of awe.” Word bank: moments, expression, accordingly, improvisations

   Key: moments

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 19? "Yet I should fail in any attempt to convey an idea of the exact character of the studies, or of the _____, in which he involved me, or led me the way."

   A. improvisations
   B. occupations
   C. accordingly
   D. reminiscences

   Key: B (occupations)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 11: "And now in the mere _____ of the prevailing character of these features, and of the expression they were wont to convey, lay so much of change that I doubted to whom I spoke." Word bank: exaggeration, Nevertheless, cataleptical, insoluble

   Key: exaggeration

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 17? "A settled apathy, a gradual wasting away of the person, and frequent although transient affections of a partially _____ character, were the unusual diagnosis."

   A. cataleptical
   B. difficulty
   C. importunate
   D. occupations

   Key: A (cataleptical)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 5? "It was the manner in which all this, and much more, was said—it was the apparent heart that went with his request—which allowed me no room for hesitation; and I _____ obeyed forthwith what I still considered a very singular summons."

   A. accordingly
   B. moments
   C. reminiscences
   D. insufferable

   Key: A (accordingly)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 11? "The silken hair, too, had been suffered to grow all unheeded, and as, in its wild gossamer texture, it floated rather than fell about the face, I could not, even with effort, connect its Arabesque _____ with any idea of simple humanity."

    A. cataleptical
    B. imagination
    C. experiment
    D. expression

    Key: D (expression)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · RL.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 4: "It was a mystery all _____; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered." Word bank: insoluble,

reminiscences, cataleptical, experiment

Key: insoluble

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.5] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “I say insufferable; for the feeling was unrelieved by any of that half-pleasurable, because poetic, sentiment, with which the mind usually…”

    B. “I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of insufferable gloom pervaded my spirit.”

    C. “What was it—I paused to think—what was it that so unnerved me in the contemplation of the House of Usher?”

    D. “There was an iciness, a sinking, a sickening of the heart—an unredeemed dreariness of thought which no goading of the imagination could…”

    Key: B (“I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of insufferable gloom pervaded my spirit.”)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 11 reveal about the character or situation? “The now ghastly pallor of the skin, and the now miraculous lustre of the eye, above all things startled and even awed me.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11) accurately and quotes “miraculous” and “startled”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 21 reveal about the character or situation? “The verses, which were entitled "The Haunted Palace," ran very nearly, if not accurately, thus:” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 21) accurately and quotes “accurately” and “entitled”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

15. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 72 reveal about the character or situation? “Its immense weight caused an unusually sharp grating sound, as it moved upon its hinges.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 72) accurately and quotes “unusually” and “grating”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 73 shapes its tone: “Our glances, however, rested not long upon the dead—for we could not regard her unawed.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 73) accurately and quotes “glances” and “however”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 12 shapes its tone: “In the manner of my friend I was at once struck with an incoherence—an inconsistency; and I soon found this to arise from a series of feeble and futile struggles to overcome an habitual trepidancy—an excessive nervous agitation.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 12) accurately and quotes “inconsistency” and “incoherence”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 74 to the story's treatment of the double: “There were times, indeed, when I thought his unceasingly agitated mind was laboring with some oppressive secret, to divulge which he struggled for the necessary courage.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 74) accurately and quotes “unceasingly” and “oppressive”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to the double and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 6 reveal about the character or situation? “Although, as boys, we had been even intimate associates, yet I really knew little of my friend.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 6) accurately and quotes “associates” and “intimate”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It then states the inference in one sentence and backs it with that detail.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 11 shapes its tone: “Surely, man had never before so terribly altered, in so brief a period, as had Roderick Usher!” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11) accurately and quotes “terribly” and “Roderick”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 4 shapes its tone: “What was it—I paused to think—what was it that so unnerved me in the contemplation of the House of Usher?” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 4) accurately and quotes “contemplation” and “unnerved”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 18 shapes its tone: “For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to alleviate the melancholy of my friend.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 18) accurately and quotes “unmentioned” and “melancholy”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The

unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 11 to the story's treatment of fear and the imagination: “A glance, however, at his countenance, convinced me of his perfect sincerity.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11) accurately and quotes “countenance” and “convinced”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to fear and the imagination and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

24. [short · inference · DOK 2 · RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Roderick's prophecy. The words “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm,…” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) are the evidence: their wording makes this point in the text itself.

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 69 shapes its tone: “The result was discoverable, he added, in that silent, yet importunate and terrible influence which for centuries had moulded the destinies of his family, and which made him what I now saw him—what he was.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 69) accurately and quotes “discoverable” and “importunate”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 19 to the story's treatment of the double: “I shall ever bear about me a memory of the many solemn hours I thus spent alone with the master of the House of Usher.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 19) accurately and quotes “master” and “solemn”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to the double and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

27. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.11-12.4] Which literary element does this describe in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images.

    A. Imagery
    B. Allusion
    C. Conflict
    D. Irony

    Key: A (Imagery)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 74 shapes its tone: “The pallor of his countenance had assumed, if possible, a more ghastly hue—but the luminousness of his eye had utterly gone out.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 74) accurately and quotes “luminousness” and “countenance”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 5 to the story's treatment of fear and the imagination: “The writer spoke of acute bodily illness—of a mental disorder which oppressed him—and of an earnest desire to see me, as his best, and indeed his only personal friend, with a view of attempting, by the cheerfulness of my society, some…” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 5) accurately and quotes “cheerfulness” and “alleviation”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to fear and the imagination and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 4 to the story's treatment of the double: “I was forced to fall back upon the unsatisfactory conclusion, that while, beyond doubt, there are combinations of very simple natural objects which have the power of thus affecting us, still the analysis of this power lies among…” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 4) accurately and quotes “considerations” and “unsatisfactory”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to the double and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 69 to the story's treatment of fear and the imagination: “The belief, however, was connected (as I have previously hinted) with the gray stones of the home of his forefathers.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 69) accurately and quotes “forefathers” and “previously”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to fear and the imagination and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 21 to the story's treatment of fear and the imagination: “It was, perhaps, the narrow limits to which he thus confined himself upon the guitar, which gave birth, in great measure, to the fantastic character of his performances.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 21) accurately and quotes “performances” and “fantastic”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to fear and the imagination and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

33. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 19 shapes its tone: “By the utter simplicity, by the nakedness of his designs, he arrested and overawed attention.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 19) accurately and quotes “simplicity” and “attention”,

saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It explains the tone those words create (for example, whether they make the moment tense, ironic or tender) and why the author chose them. The unit's reading of fear and the imagination: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

34. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · L.11-12.4] In the line “It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.”, what does “despaired” most nearly mean?

    A. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

    B. pure; not mixed with anything else

    C. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    D. a feeling of alarm or dread

    Key: C (abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart)

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 20 to the story's treatment of the double: “A small picture presented the interior of an immensely long and rectangular vault or tunnel, with low walls, smooth, white, and without interruption or device.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A model answer paraphrases the passage (paragraph 20) accurately and quotes “interruption” and “rectangular”, saying what those words show about the speaker or situation at that moment. It links the passage to the double and to one other named moment in the story. The unit's reading of the double: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	10, 8, 1, 2, 9, 5, 11, 6, 4, 7, 19, 12, 13, 14, 20, 21, 22, 23	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	11, 2, 3, 6, 4, 9, 5, 14, 12, 12, 24, 15, 13, 25, 22, 20, 26, 18	recall 7, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	11, 3, 4, 8, 6, 10, 12, 14, 24, 12, 15, 19, 21, 25, 27, 28, 29, 30	recall 6, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	7, 6, 2, 10, 3, 15, 12, 14, 12, 24, 13, 27, 20, 25, 22, 31, 32, 26	recall 5, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 6, 2, 24, 19, 12, 15, 25, 17, 20, 27, 28, 33, 30, 26, 23, 31, 32	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Freshman	34, 3, 10, 14, 15, 12, 13, 27, 17, 22, 25, 28, 20, 31, 32, 23, 26, 29	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	8, 2, 14, 12, 12, 19, 25, 20, 33, 17, 27, 28, 35, 31, 32, 23, 30, 29	recall 2, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 6
College Junior	6, 2, 15, 12, 14, 27, 17, 33, 22, 20, 25, 32, 31, 26, 18, 23, 29, 30	recall 2, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 7

College Senior	4, 11, 24, 19, 28, 25, 22, 27, 21, 33, 29, 32, 18, 30, 26, 35, 23, 31	recall 2, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	7, 12, 19, 16, 27, 25, 33, 17, 28, 22, 23, 32, 31, 26, 35, 29, 18, 30	recall 1, inference 2, analysis 7, synthesis 8

Final paper

The Fall of the House of Usher: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Fall of the House of Usher and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to fear and the imagination.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Fall of the House of Usher finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of the double. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Decay of family and mind

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about decay of family and mind. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of decay of family and mind. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of decay of family and mind, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of decay of family and mind in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four

scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Fear and the imagination

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about fear and the imagination. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fear and the imagination. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fear and the imagination, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of fear and the imagination in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The double

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about the double. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the double. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the double, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of the double in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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